SUIT ESTABLISHMENT

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

Feel free to disagree with the bidding which is more or less Standard American, not 2-Over-1.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

ESTABLISHMENT LESSON

It's great when you have a suit like A K Q J 10 9, six winners just ready to lead out.
But these suits occur only rarely and then usually in the opponent's hands.
So this lesson is about making winners in suits that are not so robust.
This creating of winners is called "establishing" the suit, or perhaps "setting up" the suit.

Establishing by force:

Sometimes the play will be completely obvious, such as this hand.

The contract is 6NT and West's opening lead is the ♥Q.

♠ K 10 3
♥ K 7 2
♦ Q J 10 9 8
♣ 4 2



♠ A Q 2
♥ A 5 4
♦ K 6 3
♣ A K Q 7

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

♠ = 3 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 3 : Total = 8.

You need 4 more winners, and Dummy's ♦ suit beckons.
Win the ♥ lead, probably with your ♥A, then play ♦K and continue with the ♦ suit until the defense takes their ♦A. That is the only trick you will lose since you can easily reach Dummy's remaining ♦ winners.

Ruffing to establish a suit:

Sometimes Dummy has a long suit which would be useful for discards but you have no high cards in the suit to help establish the suit by force. If you're playing a suit contract you may be able to use ruffs to do the work.

Look at an example of this technique.

The contract is 4♠ and West leads the ♥ A K Q then switches to a trump.

Loser count: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 : Total = 4.

♠ K 4 3
♥ 8 3 2
♦ A K 9 4 2
♣ J 2

Many Declarers will decide the contract depends on the ♣ finesse, so they will pull trumps, get to Dummy and finesse East for the ♣K. And half of the time they will make their contract. Of course the other half of the time they will go down. A more expert Declarer will try to find a plan that doesn't put all her eggs in one basket.



Look at Dummy's ♦ suit. If the defender's ♦s happen to be split 3 - 3 then two winners can be set up by ruffing. But, you have to be careful with your entries. So you win the trump lead in your hand and pull one more trump, making sure you leave the ♠K in Dummy. If the trumps split 3-2 all will be well. If not then you will have to rely on the ♣ finesse. Leave the last trump out for a little while and work on ♦s. Play ♦ A K 2, ruffing the ♦2 with a high trump. IF both defenders follow suit to all three ♦s then the ♦ 9 4 are now winners. Pull the last trump by leading to Dummy's ♠K and discard your ♣ Q 10 on the good ♦s.

♠ A Q J 10 5
♥ J 9 7
♦ 6 3
♣ A Q 10

If it turns out the ♦s do not split 3-3 you will be in dummy with the ♠K and you can take the ♣ finesse.
Played correctly you will make the contract whenever East holds the ♣K but you will also make it when the ♦s split 3-3.
Two chances are definitely better than one.

Ducking to establish a suit:

Here is a nice suit for you and Dummy to have:

♦ A K 9 7 4 2



♦ 6 3

If you are playing a suit contract, say 4♥, you might well establish the suit by ruffing as you did in the last section. But if instead you are playing a notrump contract you will have to establish the suit by a different method.

The "brute force" technique would work just fine with this situation:
The contract is 6NT and West leads the ♠Q.

♠ A 3
♥ 9 3 5
♦ A K 9 7 4 2
♣ A 2



♠ K 8 5 2
♥ A K Q J
♦ 6 3
♣ K 4 3

Since this is a notrump contract count your winners.

Winner count: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 4 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 : Total = 10.

Needing 2 more winners you will naturally turn to Dummy's ♦ suit. Since there are two black suit Aces in Dummy you don't have a problem with entries so you just bang down the ♦ A K 9. As long as the suit splits 3 - 2 you will establish plenty of extra winners and you will make 6NT with ease.

BUT,

What if Dummy didn't have those two black suit entries???????

The contract is 6NT and West leads the ♠Q.

♠ 3 2
♥ 9 3 2
♦ A K 9 7 4 2
♣ 3 2



♠ A K 8 5
♥ A K Q J
♦ 6 3
♣ A K 4

Winner count: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 4 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 : Total = 10.

You must find 2 more winners and again, the only hope is Dummy's ♦ suit.
If the suit splits 3 - 2 you can establish 3 winners by playing ♦ A K 9. It won't do you any good though, since you will have zero chance of getting to Dummy to use them.

Try this instead. Win the opening lead in your hand and lead a ♦, playing a small one from Dummy. The defenders will win this trick pretty cheaply, but you don't care. You are hoping that their remaining ♦s are now split 2 - 1, in which case they will fall under Dummy's ♦ A K. And best of all, you still have a small ♦ to lead!

This technique, Ducking, is very useful when Dummy is short (or empty) of entries.

20 Deals are worth more than another 1000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



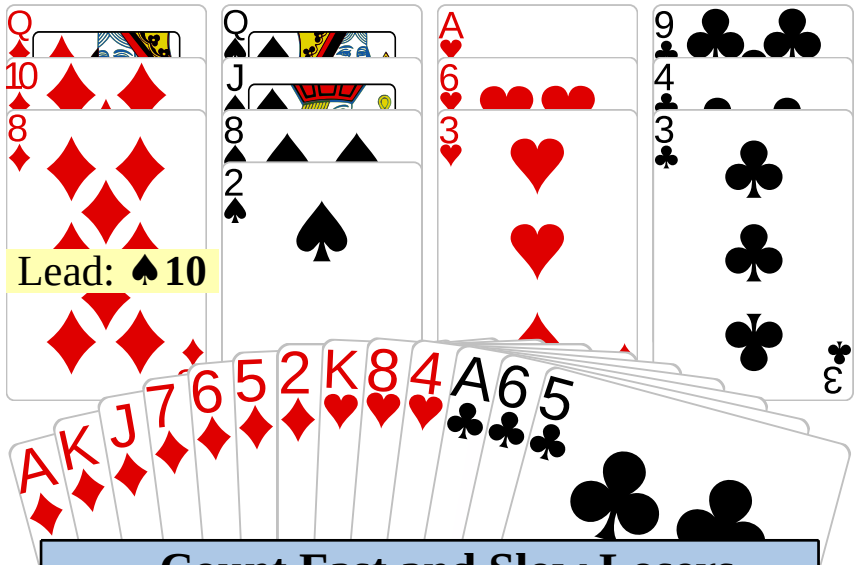
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 3 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



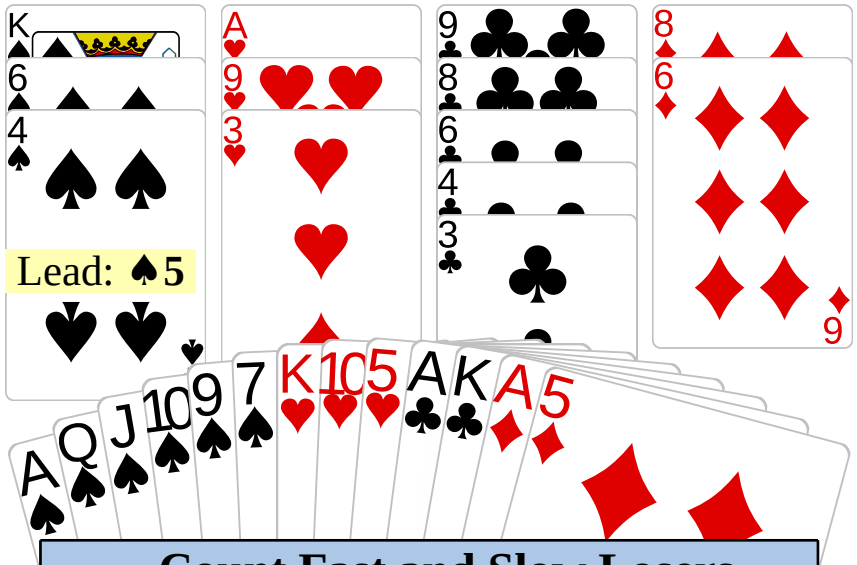
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 4 Ctr: **5♦** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 5 Ctr: **6♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠K

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠6

Board: 3
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠2

Board: 4
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 5♦
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠10

Board: 5
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠5

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ 7 4 ♥ A Q 8 6 2 ♦ Q 6 ♣ A 8 4 3	
♠ A 9 2 ♥ J 7 3 ♦ A 9 2 ♣ J 9 6 5	N W E S	♠ K Q J 10 ♥ 10 9 ♦ 7 4 3 ♣ K 10 7 2
	♠ 8 6 5 3 ♥ K 5 4 ♦ K J 10 8 5 ♣ Q	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♥	Pass	3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♠K

Some pretty agressive bidding gets you to a challenging game. North is to play 4♥. East leads the ♠K, overtaken by West's ♠A. West returns a ♠ to East's ♠10, and he then plays the ♠Q.

You ruff the third ♠.

East plays low.

West ducks.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 6

With 2 tricks already gone you still have 4 losers. You could consider ruffing the 3 ♣ losers in dummy but that would just create a trump loser even when trumps are splitting 3-2. So it looks like you will have to establish the ♦ suit for discards. You could pull trumps and then play your ♦Q, hoping the defenders will grab their ♦A immediately. But unless they are real novices they will hold it up one round and you'll no longer be able to reach dummy.

The solution is to establish the ♦s before you use up dummy's ♥K.

Ruff the third ♠, then play ♦Q, (which they will duck), and another ♦, (which they will probably take). Win whatever they return, pull trumps ending in dummy, and enjoy your 3 ♦ winners.

If West does not take the second ♦ you continue the suit, and whether you ruff or discard a loser you still make the contract.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 4 3 2 ♥ A 8 2 ♦ K J 5 ♣ Q 10 7 4	
♠ Q J 9 ♥ K Q 10 5 4 ♦ 9 4 ♣ 8 6 3	N W E S	♠ A 7 5 ♥ J 7 ♦ A 10 8 6 3 ♣ A K 5
	♠ K 10 8 6 ♥ 9 6 3 ♦ Q 7 2 ♣ J 9 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♦	Pass	2♥	Pass
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♠6

West's 3♦ bid was a transfer to ♥s, and his 2NT bid showed exactly 5 ♥s with an invitational strength hand. East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♠6, you play dummy's ♠9 and North contributes the ♠2.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 5

The math is easy - you need 4 ♥ tricks. And you should be able to manage that by driving out the ♥A. But the defenders will probably hold up one or two rounds when you play on ♥s, so you must have an outside entry to dummy.

The ♠ Q J will provide that entry **IF** you make sure to win the first trick with your ♠A as an unblocking move. If you don't do so then South will be able to keep you out of the dummy and away from those good ♥s.

Suppose you allow dummy's ♠9 to hold the first trick, then start on ♥s. North will hold up the ♥A for 1 or 2 rounds. When he does win it he will return a ♠ and whether you play the ♠A or a low ♠ South will be able to prevent you from reaching dummy.

But if you win the first trick with the ♠A, then dummy's ♠ Q J will provide a guaranteed entry to the good ♥s.

Board 3
West Deals
None Vul

	♠ K J 4 ♥ Q J 10 5 3 ♦ 7 5 4 ♣ 8 2	
♠ Q 9 7 2 ♥ K 6 4 ♦ 10 8 2 ♣ Q 6 3		♠ 8 6 3 ♥ A 8 2 ♦ Q J 9 ♣ J 10 7 4
	♠ A 10 5 ♥ 9 7 ♦ A K 6 3 ♣ A K 9 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	Pass	Pass	1♦
Pass	1♥	Pass	2NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠2

South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠2, you play dummy's ♠4 and East plays the ♠8.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=2 Total = 7

Needing just two more winners it looks straightforward to establish dummy's ♥ suit. Suppose you win the ♠10 and play the ♥9. If the defenders win this trick you are home free. You win their ♠ return with your ♠A, then continue ♥s to drive out their last stopper while you still have the ♠K as a dummy entry.

This won't work against good defenders, who will hold up on the first ♥ trick and win the second. Then when they continue ♠s you won't have another ♥ to return to dummy, so while you can use the ♠K as an entry to establish the ♥s you will never get back to use the good ones.

Instead you should win the first trick with your ♠A. Now when you attack ♥s a defensive holdup won't hurt you because you have **TWO** ♠ entries, the ♠J by a finesse and the ♠K.

West is almost certain to hold the ♠Q because his ♠2 opening lead promises an honor and the ♠Q is the only one you don't have.

So the ♠ finesse is an odds-on play to get a second dummy entry.

Board 4
South Deals
Both Vul

	♠ 10 9 6 ♥ Q 10 7 2 ♦ 9 4 3 ♣ K Q 8	
♠ — ♥ K 8 4 ♦ A K J 7 6 5 2 ♣ A 6 5	N W E S	♠ Q J 8 2 ♥ A 6 3 ♦ Q 10 8 ♣ 9 4 3
	♠ A K 7 5 4 3 ♥ J 9 5 ♦ — ♣ J 10 7 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			2♠
Dbl	Pass	2NT	Pass
3♦	Pass	4♦	Pass
5♦			
All Pass			

5♦ by West
Lead: ♠10

3NT would have been a lot easier, but you didn't get there. West is to play 5♦. North leads the ♠10.

South plays the ♠K and you ruff with the ♦2.

North plays low.

South shows out.

South covers with the ♠A.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=2 Total = 3

The good news is that you only have one loser to get rid of. The bad news is that there doesn't seem to be a good place to put it.

Unlikely as it seems, your best candidate for establishment is dummy's ♠8. North is marked with 3 ♠s, and having led the ♠10 there is a good chance that he also has the ♠9. If so you can ruff it out.

Cover the ♠10 with dummy's ♠J, and when South plays one of his honors ruff in your hand. Play a trump to the ♦10, South showing out. Lead the ♠Q. South will be forced to play his other high honor, (if he doesn't you would discard a loser), and you ruff again.

Back to dummy with the ♦Q and ruff the ♠2 with a high trump just to be safe. North drops the ♠9 on this trick.

Pull North's last trump and enter dummy with the ♥A and **FINALLY** discard a loser on the now established ♠8.

When your only hope of making a contract is for the defender's cards to be a certain way, just assume that they lie perfectly for you and barge ahead.

Here you needed ♠ 10 9 x to be with North if you were to make the contract so you played for just that holding.

Board 5
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A Q J 10 9 7 ♥ K 10 5 ♦ A 5 ♣ A K	
♠ 8 2 ♥ Q 8 2 ♦ Q 10 9 4 ♣ Q J 7 2	N W E S	♠ 5 3 ♥ J 7 6 4 ♦ K J 7 3 2 ♣ 10 5
	♠ K 6 4 ♥ A 9 3 ♦ 8 6 ♣ 9 8 6 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			Pass
Pass	2♣	Pass	2NT
Pass	3♠	Pass	4♠
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♦[2]
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

6♠ by North
Lead: ♠5

North is to play 6♠. East leads the ♠5.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 2

First pull trumps with the ♠A and ♠Q, both defenders following. Next you must establish dummy's ♣ suit to get rid of one of your losers. If the suit splits 3-3 that will be easy since you have two dummy entries, one to get there to ruff the third ♣ and the other to get there to enjoy playing the winners. But ♣s will probably split 4-2 so the two entries won't be enough. Here's how to make the defenders help you establish the suit.

After pulling trumps, play the ♣ A K, then ♦A.

You exit with a small ♦ and West wins.

The defender who won the ♦ trick has a problem. If he plays another ♦ you will get a ruff-sluff, and if he plays a ♥ you will play for the ♥Q and ♥J to be in different hands. So he will probably play a ♣.

You ruff in your hand, play a trump to dummy's ♠K and ruff the ♣8, establishing the ♣9 while you still have the ♥ entry.

Notice that this Plan would also succeed if the ♣s had split 3-3.

This was a combination of Suit Establishment and End-play. The lesson on Eliminations contains a lot more of this type of hand.